CHAPTER 8

THE HILL AND THE HAM SANDWICH

My mum drops me off at the entrance to Thompson Park. It's a two-minute walk into school through the gates, past the green bandstand that I will one day congregate under to smoke in the rain. I walk into the park, stopping just short of the bandstand, and watch her drive off into the distance. She knows that I'm not happy at St Theodore's, that I don't want to be going in. I wonder as I watch the car leave whether she even knows that I haven't been getting close to those school gates this week; that we maybe have an unsaid understanding that I don't need to if it's making me that unhappy. I've told her parts of what's going on; that I don't have any friends, that I'm getting picked on. She can see that I'm half the size of everyone I'm in a sports team with. She might even be able to sense that I'm not as good at sports as I prayed I might be when I was younger. She might notice that in social situations I've begun to bite my own tongue out of nerves.

But she doesn't know all of it. She doesn't know that when you are this age, you begin to believe what they are saying to you. That I've begun to believe I really am that small. She doesn't know that last week I was sat on the field with a few of them and, when I disagreed with what one of the boys said, he chased me around, eventually catching me, wrestling me to the floor, pinning me to the ground and rubbing his half-eaten Cornish pasty into my face until I surrender and all that is surrounding me as he does, the pack swarming as it happens, is laughter. She doesn't know that the blood covered across my England football tracksuit is not me hitting my nose on a pole, but from a headbutt, so sharp and direct and blinding that it rushed immediately across my face, painting the top red. She doesn't know that I go to sleep every night wanting to be someone else. I don't want to put that on her, or anyone else. I don't know where it comes from, and it isn't her